



City of
Philadelphia

FUNDRAISING STRATEGIES SUPPORT PROGRAM FOR AVCPG GRANTEES

COMPLETED BY:
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Executive Summary

The Fundraising Strategies Support Program, delivered by Erin Hutt Consulting as part of the City of Philadelphia's Anti-Violence Community Partnership Grant (AVCPG) initiative, provided targeted capacity-building and technical assistance to community-based organizations focused on reducing gun violence and its root causes. Operating under a contract period from January to December 2025, the program delivered workshops and one-on-one coaching from February through November, with January dedicated to preparation and December focused on evaluation and reporting. This comprehensive series of services was designed to strengthen the fundraising infrastructure of AVCPG grantees, equipping them with the tools, strategies, and, most importantly, the confidence to secure sustainable funding.

By making the fundraising process accessible and equipping leaders with donor research strategies and practical tools, the program transformed uncertainty into confident action. Organizations across all three AVCPG grant tiers, Targeted Community Investment Grants (TCIG), Community Capacity Grants (CCG), and Community Expansion Grants (CEG), received individualized support tailored to their capacity level and growth trajectory.

Program at a Glance

Through a blend of interactive workshops, individualized coaching sessions, and practical resource development, the program provided:

20 interactive workshops

delivered approximately twice monthly across two core topic areas: Fundraising Unlocked (10 sessions) and Grant Writing Fundamentals (10 sessions), with flexible scheduling to accommodate diverse needs and accessibility requirements

120 hours of personalized one-on-one strategy sessions, with organizations receiving an average of four hours of individualized coaching tailored to their specific goals, challenges, and organizational context

184 workshop participants

representing organizations across all three AVCPG funding tiers, with many organizations sending multiple staff members or attending multiple sessions to deepen their learning

Comprehensive fundraising assessments and customized action plans for all participating organizations, identifying capacity strengths, growth areas, and clear next steps



Ready-to-use tools and templates, including fundraising readiness checklists, grant research tools, proposal checklists, and event planning guides, all designed to be culturally responsive, scalable, and practical.



Measurable Impact

The program demonstrated significant outcomes in building both competence and confidence. The majority of participants reported increased assurance in identifying and applying for grants, with many beginning to implement new fundraising strategies within months of engagement. Organizations received individualized assessments and customized fundraising action plans tailored to their specific contexts and capacity levels. Participants also expanded their understanding of sponsorship and donor engagement strategies, gaining tools and frameworks to diversify their funding streams.

Importantly, the program emphasized accessibility, equity, and sustainability, directly addressing the systemic barriers faced by Black- and Brown-led organizations. By centering cultural responsiveness and peer-to-peer collaboration, the program not only built technical skills but also affirmed the leadership and expertise of community organizations on the frontlines of violence prevention.

Amplifying the City's Investment

This technical assistance program served as essential infrastructure, helping smaller grassroots organizations build the internal capacity needed to sustain their anti-violence work and move into higher funding tiers. By strengthening fundraising readiness across the AVCPG ecosystem, the program amplified the City's \$24 million investment in 147 community-based organizations, ensuring that these critical resources translate into long-term community impact.

The following report details the services delivered, outcomes achieved, and key insights gained over the course of the program. It also includes citywide recommendations to strengthen Philadelphia's ecosystem of anti-violence community-based organizations through strategic, equity-centered fundraising support.

Program Overview

of AVCPG grantees by providing practical, equity-centered guidance across three key areas: fundraising strategy development, grant writing, and resource planning. Erin Hutt Consulting implemented a multi-touchpoint approach, combining hands-on workshops, personalized one-on-one strategy sessions, and custom tools to meet the diverse needs of participating organizations.

Over the course of the year, the program delivered:

20 Fundraising Workshops:

Conducted approximately twice per month from February through November, these 90-minute sessions provided grantees with structured learning opportunities across two core topic areas. Workshops were delivered in a hybrid format, offering both in-person and virtual participation options to accommodate accessibility needs and organizational schedules. Each session included actionable content, real-world examples, and opportunities for peer-to-peer learning and collaboration.



Fundraising Unlocked (10 sessions)

This workshop series equipped participants with essential fundraising strategies to secure sustainable funding for anti-violence initiatives. Sessions covered grant research and management, donor acquisition and retention, corporate and event sponsorship development, and fundraising event planning. Participants received customized fundraising strategy documents, draft templates for donor outreach and grant proposals, and targeted lists of funding sources relevant to their work.



Grant Writing Fundamentals (10 sessions)

This series provided comprehensive training on mastering the grant process from start to finish. Participants learned effective grant research techniques to identify best-fit opportunities, strategies for crafting persuasive and competitive proposals, and best practices for tracking and managing grants to strengthen relationships with funders. Each session delivered practical tools, including grant research templates, proposal checklists, and management systems designed for immediate implementation.

120 Hours of One-on-One Strategy Sessions

Monthly office hours offered, providing each grantee with individualized support tailored to their specific goals, challenges, and organizational capacity. These sessions offered differentiated support based on each organization's size, experience level, and growth trajectory, ensuring that grassroots organizations received foundational guidance while more established organizations focused on scaling their efforts. Sessions began with a comprehensive organizational assessment and culminated in the development of a custom fundraising action plan for each organization. Follow-up support included ongoing virtual office hours, email check-ins to address emerging needs, and tailored resources based on each organization's progress.

Custom Tools and Template

Participants were equipped with ready-to-use fundraising resources designed to support immediate action and long-term sustainability. Materials included a fundraising readiness checklist, a grant research tracker, a proposal checklist, and a fundraising event planning guide. All tools were designed to be culturally responsive, scalable, and practical for organizations at various stages of development, from grassroots startups to established nonprofits seeking to expand their resource base.

Grantees served through the program were part of the City of Philadelphia's TCIG, CCG, and CEG cohorts. Services were delivered on the following timelines:



By providing consistent, tailored support across these groups, the program aimed not only to strengthen each organization's internal fundraising infrastructure but also to contribute to a stronger, more connected ecosystem of anti-violence organizations across Philadelphia.

To ensure the Fundraising Strategies Support Program was both impactful and responsive to grantee needs, Erin Hutt Consulting implemented a structured evaluation framework grounded in feedback, reflection, and measurable outcomes.

The evaluation process was anchored by pre- and post-workshop surveys, administered to all participating organizations. These surveys were designed to assess changes in participants' knowledge, confidence, and readiness to implement key fundraising strategies. Pre-surveys were completed before each workshop session to establish baseline data on the specific topic being covered, while post-surveys captured growth in those areas and gathered feedback on the effectiveness of the content and delivery. All organizations that attended a workshop participated in the corresponding survey process.

Key areas assessed through the surveys included:

- Confidence in identifying and applying for grants
- Knowledge of fundraising best practices
- Readiness to engage donors, pursue sponsorships, and host events
- Understanding of organizational fundraising capacity and infrastructure needs
- Satisfaction with tools and templates provided
- Feedback on the value of workshops and one-on-one sessions

In addition to quantitative metrics, participants were invited to provide qualitative feedback through open-ended survey questions and follow-up conversations during one-on-one strategy sessions. This feedback provided rich insight into the program's most impactful elements and highlighted areas where organizations experienced transformational growth.

Workshop attendance and participation in one-on-one strategy sessions were also tracked to assess program reach and utilization of services. Data from these sources was aggregated and analyzed to inform both individual grantee outcomes and citywide trends. The evaluation framework not only helped document grantee progress but also ensured that services remained relevant and aligned with the unique challenges faced by AVCPG organizations throughout the year.

Grantee Outcomes and Deliverables

Throughout the year, AVCPG grantees engaged in a comprehensive set of capacity-building activities designed to improve their fundraising readiness and long-term sustainability. Erin Hutt Consulting delivered tangible, customized resources and guided organizations in developing actionable strategies to strengthen their fundraising infrastructure.

Tangible Deliverables for Grantees

Each workshop participant received access to a suite of practical tools and resources tailored to enhance their fundraising capabilities:

- A Fundraising Readiness Checklist to assess organizational preparedness
- A Grant Research Template to systematically identify funding opportunities
- A Grant Proposal Checklist to ensure competitive applications
- A Fundraising Event Planning Template to guide successful event execution

Organizations that participated in one-on-one strategy sessions received comprehensive assessments and customized action plans. These individualized resources identified organizational strengths, growth areas, and capacity needs, providing clear goals, action steps, and implementation timelines tailored to each organization's unique context.

All tools were designed to be user-friendly and adaptable, empowering grantees to take immediate and sustainable action regardless of their organization's size or stage of development.

Participant Outcomes and Impact

Grantee feedback and survey data demonstrated meaningful growth in both confidence and capacity. The majority of participating organizations reported increased assurance in identifying and applying for grants, with many noting that the program helped them move from feeling overwhelmed by the fundraising process to feeling equipped and prepared. Organizations showed notable improvements in their understanding of sponsorship and donor engagement strategies, with participants reporting greater clarity on how to build sustainable funding pipelines.

Many organizations reported implementing new fundraising strategies during or shortly after they engaged with the program. The individualized coaching approach proved particularly valuable, with participants noting that tailored support helped them translate general fundraising concepts into specific, actionable plans aligned with their organizational capacity and community context.

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Voices from the Field

Participants shared powerful examples of how the program transformed their approach to fundraising:

On Enhanced Grant Strategy

"I've written grants before, but this workshop really simplified the process and gave me new strategies for researching opportunities and making funder connections I hadn't thought of." Mastermind Co-Op

On Tangible Results

"The strategies we discussed in our biweekly sessions were game-changing. We secured a donated venue for our gala and brought in new sponsors, including partnerships with Indigenous educators we never would have connected with otherwise." Indigenous Educators

On Building Foundational Skills

"We were brand new to fundraising and had interns ready to help, but no clear plan. Working together, we developed a strategy to capture compelling content for our end-of-year campaign that actually connected their work to our mission." Currently Trending

On Organizational Growth

The one-on-one coaching helped us identify an entirely new revenue stream for our organization. We also found funders we didn't know existed and started building real donor relationships for the first time." Fruits of the Family Table

Several organizations noted that the individualized approach helped them "finally organize their ideas into a fundable plan." Others shared that the workshops provided "real-world examples that made fundraising feel less intimidating." Many expressed appreciation for the safe, collaborative learning environment and for the cultural relevance of the provided materials.

Overall, the deliverables and support provided through the Fundraising Strategies Support Program positioned AVCPG grantees to improve their resource development strategies and strengthen their ability to sustain anti-violence initiatives in the communities they serve.

Citywide Insights and Recommendations

As part of the Fundraising Strategies Support Program, Erin Hutt Consulting identified several key trends across AVCPG grantees that offer valuable insight into the broader fundraising landscape for community-based anti-violence organizations in Philadelphia. These findings are drawn from direct engagement with grantees, survey data, and observations collected throughout the year.

Citywide Insights

1. Fundraising Capacity Varies Widely

While some grantees entered the program with existing development strategies in place, many, particularly smaller grassroots organizations, lacked the infrastructure, tools, or dedicated staff needed to pursue funding opportunities consistently. This variance reinforces the need for differentiated support models based on organizational size and maturity.

2. Grant Research and Application Are Primary Challenges

Across all grantee types, identifying the right funding opportunities and writing competitive proposals emerged as two of the most commonly cited barriers. Organizations often feel overwhelmed by the volume of opportunities or unclear about funder expectations, resulting in missed opportunities and under-resourced programs.

3. Infrastructure Gaps Impact Fundraising Readiness

Several organizations lacked core materials and systems essential to presenting a compelling case to funders. The most frequently identified gaps included donor databases, software to automate backend systems and donor management, case statements, outcome data, and internal tracking systems. This challenge was particularly acute for organizations without full-time development staff, making it difficult to build and maintain sustainable funding pipelines.

4. Desire for Collaboration

Many grantees expressed interest in collaborating with other AVCPG organizations, especially on joint funding opportunities or shared events. Peer learning during workshops sparked connections that could be formalized in future programming. Organizations recognized the value of collective action and shared resources in strengthening their impact throughout Philadelphia's violence-prevention ecosystem.

5. Equity-Focused Support Is Essential

Organizations led by or serving Black and Brown communities shared that culturally relevant tools, clear language, and affirming spaces helped reduce the anxiety and gatekeeping often associated with traditional fundraising practices. The program's equity-centered approach was consistently identified as a key strength, distinguishing it from other professional development experiences.

Recommendations for the City of Philadelphia



Based on the insights gathered throughout the year, we recommend that the City of Philadelphia consider the following strategies to strengthen the capacity and sustainability of AVCPG grantees and the broader ecosystem of anti-violence organizations.

1. Sustain and Expand Differentiated Technical Assistance

We recommend the City continue offering tailored capacity-building support across grant cycles, with particular attention to smaller grassroots organizations. A tiered technical assistance model that meets organizations where they are, with the entry-level backing for emerging nonprofits and advanced coaching for established organizations, would maximize the impact of the City's investment. This differentiated approach ensures that all grantees, regardless of size or experience, receive the specific support they need to grow sustainably.

2. Build Grant Readiness Into the Front End

We recommend offering grant-readiness workshops and resources at the application or early award stage for future AVCPG grantees. Multiple organizations reported wishing they had received fundraising training earlier in their grant cycle, particularly during the program design and budget development phases. Starting capacity building at the front end would strengthen initial proposals, set clear expectations, and position organizations for long-term success from day one. This proactive approach would also reduce the learning curve and allow grantees to implement fundraising strategies more quickly.

3. Create a Centralized Resource Hub for AVCPG Grantees

We recommend developing a shared digital resource hub or portal accessible to all AVCPG grantees. This hub could include funding calendars, proposal templates, sample materials, funder databases, and recorded workshop content. Centralizing these resources would reduce duplication of effort, support smaller teams with limited capacity, and democratize access to tools that strengthen fundraising readiness. A centralized hub would also create opportunities for knowledge sharing and peer support beyond formal programming.

4. Invest in Peer Learning and Collaboration Networks

We recommend facilitating ongoing connections between grantees through structured cohort learning, small-group coaching sessions, or city-supported collaboratives. Many participants indicated they would benefit from continued opportunities to learn from one another, share best practices, and explore collaborative funding opportunities. Formalizing these peer networks would strengthen the collective capacity of Philadelphia's anti-violence ecosystem and create a supportive community of practice that extends beyond individual organizations.

By implementing these recommendations, the City of Philadelphia can amplify the impact of its AVCPG investment, strengthen and build more sustainable community-based organizations, and create lasting infrastructure to support violence-prevention efforts across the city.



Equity and Inclusion Impact

Equity was a central pillar of the Fundraising Strategies Support Program, intentionally woven into all aspects of service delivery. As a Minority Business Enterprise (MBE) and Women's Business Enterprise (WBE), Erin Hutt Consulting brings lived experience and deep commitment to addressing systemic barriers, such as historic underfunding, racial bias in philanthropy, and limited access to institutional networks, that continue to affect Black- and Brown-led organizations.

01. Culturally Responsive Design

Workshops and templates were developed using clear, jargon-free language and real-world examples that resonated with grassroots leaders. Special care was taken to ensure that materials reflected the communities most impacted by gun violence and aligned with the grantees' lived experiences. The program explicitly challenged deficit-based narratives and funder-driven models that often disadvantage organizations led by people of color. Instead, grantees were empowered to tell their own stories, highlight community strengths, and position their work as solutions rather than charity. This narrative shift helped boost confidence and encouraged organizations to pursue more ambitious funding opportunities.

02. Safe Space for Peer Learning and Accessible Support

Each session was structured to encourage open dialogue, validation of grantee experiences, and peer-to-peer mentorship. This intentional environment fostered trust and collaboration, especially among organizations that have historically been excluded from traditional fundraising training. Recognizing that many grantees operate with limited staff and resources, the program offered flexible scheduling, virtual participation options, and individualized coaching. This helped remove logistical barriers that might otherwise prevent participation and ensured that smaller organizations were equally able to benefit from the support.

By centering equity in both content and delivery, the program not only strengthened fundraising skills but also affirmed the leadership, vision, and expertise of the community organizations on the frontlines of violence prevention.

Challenges and Lessons Learned

As with any dynamic, community-centered initiative, the Fundraising Strategies Support Program encountered challenges that offered valuable lessons to inform future capacity-building efforts. By reflecting on these experiences, we can identify opportunities to enhance the effectiveness and sustainability of technical assistance for community-based organizations.

Importance of Early Engagement

Several grantees mentioned that they wished they had received the training and tools earlier in the grant cycle, especially during program design and budget development phases. Organizations that engaged with fundraising support later in their grant period often faced compressed timelines to implement strategies while simultaneously managing program deliverables and reporting requirements. Starting capacity building earlier would have allowed organizations to build fundraising activities into their program plans from the outset, rather than adding them as supplemental efforts.

Early engagement would also enable organizations to develop stronger cases for support, establish baseline data collection systems, and build funder relationships proactively rather than reactively. Organizations that received support during their planning phases demonstrated greater confidence and preparedness in executing their fundraising strategies throughout the grant period.

Looking Forward

These challenges underscore essential opportunities for future programming. Multi-year technical assistance models that provide sustained coaching and accountability could support more profound organizational transformation and long-term sustainability. Introducing capacity-building support at the pre-award or early-award stage would position organizations for success from day one, allowing them to integrate fundraising infrastructure into their core operations rather than treating it as an add-on.

The flexibility and responsiveness built into this program enabled continuous adaptation to grantee needs. Moving forward, these insights will inform the design of more robust support systems that meet organizations where they are while providing the sustained engagement necessary for meaningful, lasting change. By investing in longer-term, front-loaded technical assistance, the City can maximize the impact of its AVCPG investment and build a stronger ecosystem of financially sustainable anti-violence organizations across Philadelphia.



Conclusion

The Fundraising Strategies Support Program successfully strengthened the capacity of AVCPG grantees to pursue sustainable funding and build the infrastructure necessary for long-term impact. Through 20 interactive workshops, 120 hours of personalized coaching, and comprehensive tools and resources, the program equipped organizations across all three grant tiers with practical strategies and, critically, the confidence to implement them.

By centering equity, cultural responsiveness, and individualized support, the program affirmed the expertise of Black- and Brown-led organizations working on the frontlines of violence prevention. The measurable growth in fundraising readiness, combined with powerful testimonials from participants, demonstrates that targeted technical assistance can transform how community-based organizations secure and sustain resources.

The insights and recommendations presented in this report offer a roadmap for the City of Philadelphia to continue building a strong, connected ecosystem of anti-violence organizations. By sustaining differentiated technical assistance, introducing capacity-building early in the grant cycle, centralizing resources, and fostering peer-learning networks, the City can ensure that its investment in community-based violence prevention yields lasting, transformative results.

Erin Hutt Consulting is grateful for the opportunity to partner with the City of Philadelphia and AVCPG grantees in this critical work. Together, we are building not just fundraising capacity, but a more equitable and sustainable future for the communities most impacted by gun violence.

